

The Freshman *Roadmap*

Plan now, don't cram later. Small steps in 9th grade make senior year calm instead of chaotic. A four-year plan built for Florida families.

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Why 9th grade *matters*

Most families start thinking about college in junior year. By then, half of the high school record is already written.

Grades count from day one

Every core course in 9th grade goes into the GPA colleges see and into the **Bright Futures GPA**. A rough first semester is fixable, but easier to avoid.

Courses build on each other

Math, science and world language follow a sequence. Choices in 9th grade decide which advanced courses are open in 11th and 12th.

Hours add up slowly

Bright Futures asks for volunteer or paid work hours **earned during high school**. A few hours a month starting now is easy. 100 hours in senior spring is not.

Habits beat cramming

A weekly check of grades, a simple log for hours and awards, and one family check-in a month. That's the whole system.

✓ Do these in the first month

- ☐ Find the school counselor's name and email, and save them in your phone
- ☐ Log in to the parent portal and learn where grades show up
- ☐ Ask the counselor how your district counts Bright Futures service hours (and whether the summer before 9th grade counts)
- ☐ Start the service hour log (page 8) and the activities log (page 9)
- ☐ Put a 20-minute "college check-in" on the family calendar once a month

The mindset: You're not choosing a college in 9th grade. You're keeping doors open, so in 12th grade your student gets to choose.

Florida graduation requirements

The standard 24-credit diploma, for students entering 9th grade in 2026-27.

Subject	Credits	Notes
English	4	English 1–4
Math	4	Must include Algebra 1 and Geometry
Science	3	Must include Biology 1; two must have a lab
Social studies	3	World History, U.S. History, U.S. Government (½) and Economics (½)
Arts	1	Fine or performing arts, speech and debate, or career and technical/practical arts
PE	1	Includes health
Personal financial literacy	½	Required for students entering 9th grade in 2023–24 and later
Electives	7½	

! Tests and GPA

- ☐ Pass the Grade 10 English Language Arts test (or earn a concordant score)
- ☐ Pass the Algebra 1 end-of-course exam (or earn a comparative score)
- ☐ End-of-course exams in Algebra 1, Geometry, Biology 1 and U.S. History count for **30%** of the course grade
- ☐ Take the U.S. Government civic literacy test (taking it is required; passing is not)
- ☐ Graduate with at least a 2.0 unweighted GPA

★ Worth knowing

Scholar designation

Extra recognition on the diploma: Algebra 2 and statistics (or equally rigorous courses), chemistry or physics plus one more equally rigorous science, 2 credits of one world language, at least one AP, IB, AICE or dual enrollment course, and passing the Geometry, Biology 1 and U.S. History end-of-course exams.

18-credit option (ACCEL)

Florida also has an 18-credit accelerated diploma option with no PE requirement and fewer electives. Ask the counselor whether it fits your student.

Bright Futures, *explained early*

It can pay 75% to 100% of tuition and applicable fees at Florida public colleges and universities. Here's what your student needs, and what to start now.

The 16 core credits

The Bright Futures GPA only uses these: 4 English, 4 math (Algebra 1 or higher), 3 natural science, 3 social science and **2 credits of the same world language**.

Weighted courses help

Honors, AP, IB, AICE and academic dual enrollment courses add 0.5 per year-long course (0.25 per semester) to the Bright Futures GPA.

Volunteer or work hours

Academic Scholars: 100 volunteer hours, 100 paid work hours or a combination. Medallion: 75 volunteer hours, 100 paid work hours or a combination totaling 100. Hours must be earned during high school, documented, and signed by your student, a parent and the organization. Your district approves which activities count.

A test score, later

Scores for the Class of 2030 aren't published yet. For the Class of 2028, Academic Scholars need SAT 1350, ACT 29 or CLT 96, and Medallion needs SAT 1200, ACT 25 or CLT 83, plus a 3.5 or 3.0 weighted GPA. Requirements have been rising.

✓ Bright Futures to-dos for 9th grade

- ☐ Get your district's service hour form and approved activity list
- ☐ Log hours as they happen and turn them in at the end of every school year
- ☐ Start a world language your student can continue for two years
- ☐ Choose honors or advanced classes where your student is ready for them
- ☐ Remember the last step, years from now: the FFAA in senior year. Bright Futures is never automatic

The four-year *game plan*

One small focus per year. This is the “don't cram later” part.

9th: build habits

- ☐ Strong grades in core classes
- ☐ Start the hour log
- ☐ Begin a world language
- ☐ Try 1–2 activities
- ☐ Spring: PSAT 8/9 if your school offers it

10th: go deeper

- ☐ Add rigor where ready (honors, AP, AICE, IB)
- ☐ Spring: PSAT 10 if offered
- ☐ Ask about dual enrollment
- ☐ Keep logging hours
- ☐ Summer job, program or project

11th: the big year

- ☐ Fall: PSAT/NMSQT (the National Merit qualifier)
- ☐ Winter or spring: SAT, ACT or CLT
- ☐ Bright Futures evaluation
- ☐ Build a college list, visit campuses
- ☐ Ask teachers for recs in spring if schools require them

12th: apply + pay

- ☐ Early deadlines start mid-October
- ☐ FAFSA in the fall
- ☐ FFAA for Bright Futures
- ☐ Scholarships monthly
- ☐ Compare aid, then decide by May 1

Our family's goals

By the end of 9th grade, we want...

Interests to explore...

Keep it light: The goal is steady progress, not a résumé factory. One meaningful activity beats five your student doesn't care about.

9th grade, *month by month*

About 20 minutes a month. Check them off as you go.

Aug – Sept

settle in

- ☐ Save the counselor's contact info and log in to the parent portal
- ☐ Ask how your district handles Bright Futures service hours
- ☐ Start the hour log and the activities log
- ☐ Help your student pick one or two activities to try

Oct – Nov

first check

- ☐ Review progress reports together. Catch slipping grades early
- ☐ Find tutoring or teacher help hours if a class is hard
- ☐ Look for a volunteer opportunity your student would actually enjoy

Dec – Jan

mid-year

- ☐ Look at first-semester grades: what worked, what didn't?
- ☐ Turn in any hours your school wants logged mid-year
- ☐ Update the activities log with awards and roles

Feb – Mar

plan 10th grade

- ☐ Course selection for 10th grade: talk about honors and advanced options
- ☐ Keep the world language going for a second year
- ☐ Ask the counselor about dual enrollment timing

Apr – May

finish strong

- ☐ Spring tests: PSAT 8/9 if your school offers it, and end-of-course exams
- ☐ Turn in all service hours for the year
- ☐ Plan a summer that builds something: a job, volunteering, a program or a project

Summer

recharge + grow

- ☐ Volunteer or work (ask your district if summer hours count)
- ☐ Read for fun
- ☐ Update both logs before school starts

Four-year *course planner*

Sketch the plan in pencil with your counselor. Check it each spring at course selection.

Subject	9th grade	10th grade	11th grade	12th grade
English				
Math				
Science				
Social studies				
World language				
Arts / PE / electives				
Advanced (Honors, AP, AICE, IB, DE)				

✓ Quick checks

- ☐ Algebra 1 and Geometry are on the plan
- ☐ Biology 1 and at least two lab sciences
- ☐ Two years of the **same** world language (for Bright Futures)
- ☐ Personal financial literacy (½ credit)
- ☐ Room for at least one advanced or dual enrollment course

Service hour log

Write it down the same day. Every entry must be documented and signed by your student, a parent and the organization. Use your district's official form when you turn hours in.

Date	Organization	What we did	Hours	Contact + phone	Signed?

Running total: _____ hours. Goal: 100 (or 75 for Medallion volunteer hours). Paid work hours can count too.

Activities + *awards log*

Future applications will ask about activities, awards and jobs. This log turns senior-year guesswork into copy and paste.

Activity, award or job	Grade(s)	Role / what I did	Hours per week	Proud of

Dual enrollment, AP, IB + AICE

Four ways to take college-level work in high school. AP, IB, AICE and academic (college-credit) dual enrollment courses earn extra weight in the Bright Futures GPA.

Dual enrollment

Real college classes through a Florida college or university, counting for high school and college credit. Public school students pay no tuition or fees, and course materials are free. Open to grades 6–12. College-credit courses need a 3.0 unweighted GPA plus a qualifying placement test score; career certificate courses need a 2.0.

AP (Advanced Placement)

College-level courses taught at your high school, with an exam in May. A qualifying score can earn college credit.

IB (International Baccalaureate)

A full two-year diploma program in 11th and 12th grade at participating schools, often with pre-IB courses in 9th and 10th.

AICE (Cambridge)

A program of advanced courses and exams offered at many Florida high schools, with its own AICE diploma.

? Questions for the counselor

- ☐ Which of these does our school offer, and when can my student start?
- ☐ Which college is our district's dual enrollment partner, and what are its deadlines?
- ☐ Which placement tests count (PERT, SAT, ACT, PSAT)?
- ☐ How do these choices fit the four-year course plan?

→ A peek at what's next

- ☐ **10th:** add rigor where ready, PSAT 10 in spring, keep logging hours
- ☐ **11th:** PSAT/NMSQT in the fall, SAT/ACT/CLT, college list and visits
- ☐ **12th:** applications from mid-October, FAFSA and FFAA, scholarships, decide by May 1

Sources: Fla. Stat. 1007.271 (dual enrollment), 1003.4282 and 1003.4285 (graduation), Florida Bright Futures Student Handbook 2026–27, College Board. This roadmap is for planning help and isn't official advice; confirm with your school counselor. College Plan is not affiliated with the State of Florida or any school. © 2026 College Plan.